vessels pushed out the Filipino forces in early July, Manila appealed to Washington under its security treaty for assistance.[23]

Prior Philippine requests for US help in dealing with China had been largely shunted aside by Washington, even during the Trump administration. However, new US president Gavin Newsom, who had been dogged during the 2024 campaign by allegations that Chinese cyber operations had benefited his candidacy, saw the Philippine request as an opportunity to show his willingness to take a hard line against Beijing. Newsom increased US Air Force flights over the contested territory, using air bases made available by Manila, and sent the *Gerald Ford*, along with escort vessels, on a short transit. On two occasions in late July, US and Chinese ships came close to running into each other due to aggressive PLAN maneuvering, and a US Navy FA-18 operating from the *Gerald Ford* was forced to take emergency evasive action to avoid colliding with a PLANAF J-15.[24] Despite the increasing tensions, the US Navy ships returned to Japan at the beginning of August, yet no diplomatic attempts were made to alter the trajectory of events. The fact that both sides knew some type of armed encounter was increasingly possible, if not probable, yet seemed to ignore the risk, led pundits to call the events surrounding the clash an example of a "gray rhino," unlike the complete surprise represented by a "black swan" occurrence. Ironically, Xi Jinping himself had warned about the dangers of "gray rhinos" back in 2018 and 2019.[25]

In response to the brief uptick in US Navy FONOPS near other Chinese-claimed territory in the Spratly and Paracel island chains, Beijing decided to fortify Scarborough Shoal, building airstrips and naval facilities as it had done in the Spratlys. As Scarborough lay only 140 miles from Manila, China's announcement set off alarm bells in the Philippines.[26] As Chinese naval construction ships approached Scarborough on September 4, dozens of small Philippine boats, many of them private, attempted to block them. On the second day of the maritime encounter, a Chinese frigate rammed a Philippine fishing boat, sinking it, with the loss of two seamen.[27] As news spread over the next